

Offshore investors in town, what's the feedback?

Reforms on track, Financials constructive, Retailers talk diesel & consumer pressures. Politics has come back to the fore.

Last week, our South Africa Research team hosted a series of meetings with international investors, bringing together 21 companies and industry experts. The discussions centered on the retail and financial sectors, alongside expert perspectives on government reform initiatives and consumer trends. We left these meetings with greater confidence in our positive view on South African domestic companies — the government's reform agenda remains broadly on track, though we are increasingly cautious about the pace and effectiveness of reforms at the local government level. Financial companies, our highest-conviction investment theme within our South Africa strategy, continue to demonstrate both stability and meaningful growth potential, with our top picks being **DSY, CPI and FSR**. On the consumer side, we continue to favor staples companies for their defensive, everyday-spending exposure, while Pepkor is notably broadening its appeal by expanding into financial services — our top picks here are **PPH, SHP and TBS**. Across our broader South Africa portfolio, our high-conviction names Strategy span multiple sectors and includes **DSY, NPN, BID, SOL, ANG, FSR, CPI and CLS**. Our perception on the offshore investors was three-fold. First, investors agreed that the macro theme is improving with underlying drivers encouraging; second, conflict in the Middle East however complicates a broader SA Inc. entry point and lastly, third, political risks seem to be re-emerging. **Please reach out to us or your sales representative for a deeper debrief, including key investor takeaways and which companies resonated most strongly with the foreign investors.**

- **SA Strategy feedback:** On the macro front, three key topics dominated: a) conviction levels on the reform agenda from speakers, b) whether corporates — particularly banks — are seeing green shoots on the back of these reforms, and c) the political outlook. On the latter, guest speakers held high conviction that President Ramaphosa would resign post Friday's ConCourt ruling — a view we don't share. On reforms, the tone was broadly constructive with building momentum. Logistics was the standout — viewed as on track, with a notable expected uptick in Durban Pier 2 volumes and a credible belief that 200mt over the next 2-3 years is achievable on the rail network. Critically, the codification of the National Rail Master Plan and the separation of Transnet into law was cited as one of the key tenets of progress. Energy reforms are similarly on track, though the Independent Transmission Program — at just under 1,200km — was flagged as limited in scale and expensive for the seven pre-qualified bid winners; a larger, more ambitious program would be far more beneficial given the economies of scale on offer. The areas of concern were bulk water and local government reforms, where progress remains notably lagging. The sense we got, particularly from the Banks was that the reform agenda has started to yield results in terms of corporate loan growth. On politics, there was healthy — and at times pointed — debate around a potential presidential resignation should the ConCourt rule against Parliament. That

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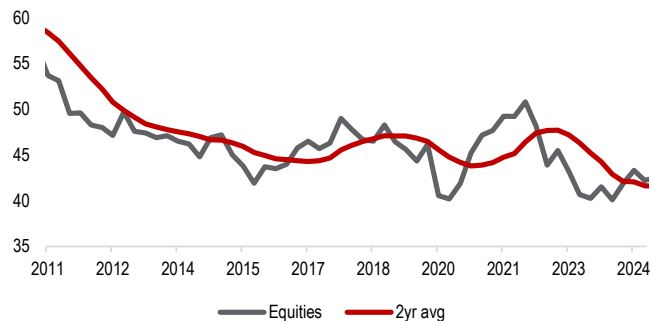
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scenario remains fluid, and as noted, has not materialised. On the broader macro debate, a recurring question was the impact of the Middle East crisis and whether the conflict has pushed out the timeline for a 2% growth handle.

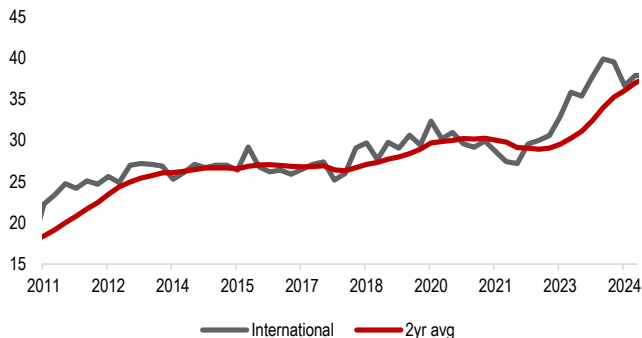
- **SA Financials Feedback:** We found the **bank discussions broadly constructive** as management teams are positioning for a multi-year uplift from South Africa's structural reforms while staying disciplined on returns and credit. Pan-African diversification and scenario planning were recurring themes (with war-linked inflation/oil risks front of mind), alongside expectations that client activity could slow with a lag as higher fuel and broader macro pressure feeds through. Competitive intensity is rising—especially in payments and select lending products—so the most consistent messages were around protecting ROE through mix, capital-light fee growth, and selective balance sheet growth rather than chasing volume. **The insurer meetings highlighted a sector increasingly driven by distribution advantage** and ecosystem strength, with “bank–insurer convergence” accelerating. Some insurers framed themselves as moving from heavy investment cycles into phases where operating leverage, cost discipline, and capital optimisation should translate into better earnings/cash generation. Competitive dynamics are also shifting toward simpler, mass-market products and lower-cost bank-linked distribution, while advice-led models are leaning harder into “human + tech” propositions. Near-term macro uncertainty (and potential pressure on persistency) remains a watch point, with Value of New Business not expected to increase materially in the short-medium term, but the tone was that well-positioned platforms can defend margins through data-driven underwriting, pricing agility, and cross-sell.
- **SA Consumer Feedback:** Rising diesel and petrol prices directly account for less than 1% of sales for most companies, and are generally viewed as less disruptive than load-shedding. As a result, most companies aim to limit the impact on consumers and offset higher costs through efficiency gains where possible. **There has been a lag in passing these costs through, as many firms had previously built up buffers to manage such periods before making price adjustments.** The main concern now is whether demand will remain robust, given the pressure on discretionary income and the heightened risk of interest rate hikes. Overall, the sector's total market size isn't expanding, but the winners are those gaining market share, as competition is intensifying across the space with the lower end of the market continuing to demonstrate resilience.

Figure 1: Long-term SA Equity Allocation



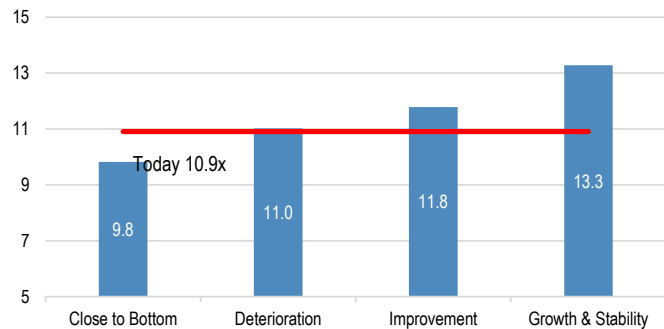
Source: Alexander Forbes Global Large Manager Watch

Figure 2: Long-term International Allocation



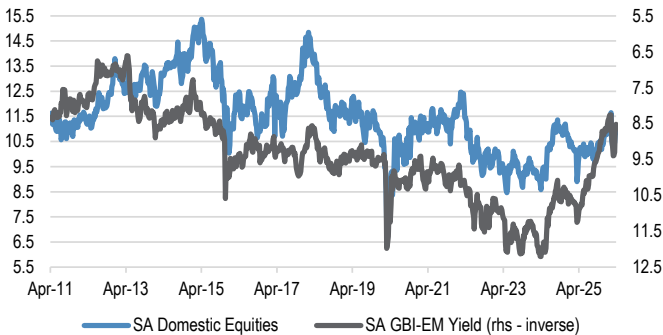
Source: Alexander Forbes Global Large Manager Watch

Figure 3: A path towards Growth & stability (13.3x fwd PE) translates to +22% upside for domestic equities



Source: J.P. Morgan Global Markets Strategy, Bloomberg Finance L.P.

Figure 4: Reforms will push SAGBs lower creating a window for broader SA Inc. rally



Source: J.P. Morgan estimates, Bloomberg Finance L.P.

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